Received: 29 November 2022 | Accepted: 13 August 2023

DOI: 10.1002/poi3.360

RESEARCH ARTICLE

Support for misinformation regulation on social media: It is the perceived harm of misinformation that matters, not the perceived amount

Isabelle Freiling[1] | **Marlis Stubenvoll**[2] | **Jörg Matthes**[3]

[1]Department of Communication, University of Utah, Salt Lake City, Utah, USA

[2]Department of Media and Communications, University of Klagenfurt, Klagenfurt am Wörthersee, Austria

[3]Department of Communication, University of Vienna, Vienna, Austria

Correspondence

Jörg Matthes, Department of Communication, University of Vienna, Währinger Str 29, 1090 Vienna, Austria.
Email: joerg.matthes@univie.ac.at

Abstract

Responding to harmful content on social media, calls for regulations are coming up to break down the black boxes of social media platforms in handling misinformation. Examples are requiring cooperations with fact-checkers or the government stepping in. So far, there is a lack of knowledge about predictors of policy attitudes in the context of misinformation besides attitudes toward and perceptions of censorship. Using a two-wave panel study in Germany at the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic and 8 months in, we examine the role of perceived misinformation exposure, perceived harm of misinformation, and trust in institutions involved in regulating misinformation on public support for misinformation regulation. Results show that trust in media and democracy increases policy support over time. Furthermore, perceived exposure to misinformation does not influence policy attitudes, but perceived harm of misinformation does. We discuss the implications for regulating misinformation in light of our findings.

KEYWORDS

fact-checking, misinformation, policy support, social media, trust

Several events over the last few years, of which we are outlining three, showed that social media platforms have struggled to control the spread of misinformation. First, in the 2016 US presidential election, false and hyper-partisan stories on social media proliferated, laying

This is an open access article under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial License, which permits use, distribution and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited and is not used for commercial purposes. © 2023 The Authors. *Policy & Internet* published by Wiley Periodicals LLC on behalf of Policy Studies Organization.

bare problems in the lack of regulation of content. In response, Facebook started automatic flagging of content and working with fact-checkers (Mosseri, 2017). Second, misinformation about the COVID-19 pandemic was discussed heavily and labeled as an "infodemic" early on (World Health Organization, 2020). Even though there is a lack of evidence for a "novel" crisis of misinformation (Scheufele et al., 2021), platforms acted on the misinformation surrounding the pandemic by "promoting public health information and downgrading disinformation" (Flew, 2021, p. 176). Third, despite new self-regulatory efforts, social media platforms were accused of a failure to regulate misinformation on the 2020 US presidential election, which might have laid the ground for a Capitol riot by supporters of former US President Trump aiming to overturn his election defeat (Morris, 2021). Consequently, the regulatory pressure on social media platforms has increased, not only from governmental bodies, but also from within (Gani, 2021).

Besides social media platforms' efforts, policymakers are working on governmental regulation in response to harmful content on social media. The German Network Enforcement Law (Netzwerkdurchsetzungsgesetz) was already passed in 2017 (Gorwa, 2019). Calls for regulating social media more are, however, still coming up: In early 2021, Germany's President Franz-Walter Steinmeier called for stronger regulation of social media (Groß, 2021). Meanwhile, also bi-partisan support for the regulation of social media is increasing in the United States (Gani, 2021).

Platforms are a black box to anyone not working for the respective platform (Freiling et al., 2021). Researchers, as well as practitioners, therefore do not know which claims platforms judge as worthy to intervene or which fact-checks platforms decide *not* to show alongside misinformation (Riedl, Whipple, et al., 2021), possibly to keep their ad revenue up. External regulation could avoid this and break up this black box. At the same time, regulating misinformation on social media also restricts free speech. "In most democratic countries, freedom of speech is institutionalized, making it a constitutionally protected human right, as it is the basis of free thought and human life" (Einwiller & Kim, 2020, p. 188). As our study was conducted in Germany, we define free speech for the purpose of this paper in line with the German constitution Article 5, Paragraphs 1 and 2 as the basic right for everyone to freely voice and distribute their opinion, which is only limited by other basic laws. Research on policy support of platform regulation in the United States has shown that while individuals' opposition to censorship is negatively associated with support for platform regulation, perceived intentional censorship of platforms is positively associated with support for platform regulation (Riedl, Whipple, et al., 2021).

Besides attitudes toward and perceptions of censorship, there is still a lack of knowledge about what drives the public to support breaking up the black boxes of platforms through policies. Does the perceived exposure to misinformation lead to stronger demands for regulation? Or is the perceived harm of misinformation more relevant in this context? Which role does trust in key actors involved in misinformation regulation play? Using a two-wave panel study, we examine how public support for misinformation regulation on social media develops in Germany from early 2020 to autumn 2020, in a time during the COVID-19 pandemic and with heavy discussions around misinformation. We advance current research by addressing the role of citizens' perceptions of misinformation (perceived exposure to misinformation and perceived harm of misinformation) alongside the wider context of institutional trust (trust in media and trust in democracy).

MISINFORMATION REGULATION ON SOCIAL MEDIA

There are different definitions of misinformation (Scheufele & Krause, 2019; Vraga & Bode, 2020). For the purpose of this paper, we understand it as an umbrella term for information not in line with the best available evidence, be it intentionally false (i.e.,

disinformation) or by mistake (Krause et al., 2020; Scheufele & Krause, 2019). The reasoning behind this is that it is often not clear which intentions a source had when sharing false information, because that would require the ability to read the source's mind. Toward that end, some also use the term fake news as an umbrella term for any false information. However, prominent uses of the term fake news are as a genre describing made-up news stories that are made to look like they came from prestigious media outlets and as a label to delegitimize content that people disagree with (Egelhofer & Lecheler, 2019). In this study, we therefore use the term misinformation and specify which definition of fake news the studies we are citing use.

Misinformation is frequently mentioned as one of several harmful content types that social media platforms try to govern and control (Banko et al., 2020; DeCook et al., 2022). Harm on social media refers to "loss or damage to a person's right, property, or well-being, whether physical or mental" (Schoenebeck & Blackwell, 2021, p. 7). An analysis of social media platforms' policy documents shows that platforms frequently refer to different forms of physical and psychological harms, for instance mentioning inciting violence, harassment, or causing economic harm, to justify policies that regulate content (DeCook et al., 2022). Furthermore, reducing harm is a moral, and in part also legal, responsibility of social media platforms (Einwiller & Kim, 2020).

The aim of mitigating harm also underlies regulatory efforts to curb the spread of misinformation (Baker et al., 2020; Schoenebeck & Blackwell, 2021). Specifically, misinformation might inflict harm to individuals and societies based on its potential to erode trust, bias decision-making, and have negative impacts on politics and health (Banko et al., 2020; Flynn et al., 2017; Hameleers, 2022). In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, regulations in some online spaces have become increasingly restrictive when it comes to sharing information that is unsupported or false: two major social media platforms, Twitter and YouTube, extended their definition of harmful content to explicitly include information that contradicted medical information by public health authorities (Baker et al., 2020).

Platforms' existing interventions against the spread of misinformation comprise internal as well as external measures. Internal measures include platforms enforcing their content policies by removing content that violates guidelines such as content that is harmful. A discourse analysis of platforms' policy documents shows that platforms render "harm" as a "floating signifier" (DeCook et al., 2022, p. 73) as there is no fixed understanding of what content is harmful and in need of moderation in these documents. While this might be necessary because platforms cannot foresee every possible harm, this vagueness makes it hard to hold platforms accountable for their content (non-)moderation (DeCook et al., 2022). Another internal measure is banning users who spread misinformation. YouTube, for instance, bans its users after sharing misinformation three times within 90 days (Duffy, 2021).

External measures include platforms' cooperation with external actors, which also serves to increase transparency and accountability in judging what is misinformation. Since 2018, YouTube uses information panels for certain topics that it considers prone to misinformation (Culliford, 2020). These information panels provide links to external sources like Encyclopedia Britannica or the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. Another example is Facebook working with fact-checkers, who can affect "which content and fact-checked stories appear next to original posts" (Medzini, 2022, p. 14). In May 2020, Facebook also implemented an external oversight board. The board makes decisions on content in specific cases (to which Facebook must comply) and provides broader policy change suggestions. Facebook does not have to comply with these broader suggestions, but if it does not, it must explain publicly why they were rejected (Medzini, 2022). However, the oversight board reported that they failed "to implement platform policies and that Facebook had concealed a number of things from the public" (DeCook et al., 2022, pp. 73

and 74). In line with the Code of Practice on Disinformation that platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Google started signing in 2018, platforms are providing monthly reports that include their efforts to limit the spread of COVID-19 disinformation and related advertising. The platforms also agreed to cooperate more with fact-checkers and researchers and to make their implementation of policies on informing users who engage with disinformation more transparent (European Commission, 2020a).

Compared to these interventions by platforms, governmental regulation is more binding. However, governmental regulation also has to consider many issues to effectively address identified problems without engaging in overreach. A recent framework for evaluating policy options that can help determining whether to regulate a certain platform suggests "determining a platform's characteristics, relating these to public interests, and formulating policy options" (Nooren et al., 2018, p. 264). Intervening due to public interests can be considered from several perspectives, including: (a) from an economic perspective, following public interest theory (Posner, 1974), the primary justification for interventions is market failure; and (b) from a normative perspective "of fundamental rights and freedoms, which is based on ethical and legal norms" (Nooren et al., 2018, p. 276). While policymakers may try to reduce the improper influence of platforms with their interventions, they also need to make sure that those interventions will not induce improper influence through government overreach (Nooren et al., 2018).

Additional challenges in developing policy options are the often rapid changes that platforms make (e.g., in their algorithms or guidelines) as well as future misinformation potentially taking different shapes. Policy options therefore need to anticipate those changes or be broad enough to still apply when changes happen (Andersson Schwarz, 2017; Nooren et al., 2018). When policies are phrased broadly, it can, however, be difficult to hold, for example, platforms accountable for not following them in specific circumstances (DeCook et al., 2022). Of course, implemented policy interventions should be evaluated to see their effect on the platform's business model and whether they had the expected effect and no negative consequences on public interests (Nooren et al., 2018). However, this evaluation is complicated by platforms not sharing their data, resulting in policymakers not being able to fully see the implications of implemented interventions (Andersson Schwarz, 2017).

Even though this can be very difficult in practice, governmental regulation can theoretically break up the black boxes of social media platforms. Governmental regulation can, for example, better ensure that platforms are not continuing to spread a claim determined as false than self-regulation might, because it might be more in line with platforms' business model of selling attention to content to show the false claim than showing people fact-checks (Pohle & Voelsen, 2022). Toward that end, Germany implemented its Network Enforcement Law in 2017. This law mandates platforms to remove content that is unlawful within 24 h of a complaint about the content and to be transparent about the removal of hate speech (Gorwa, 2019; Medzini, 2022). In other countries, such governmental regulations are still scarce, but proposals for regulations exist, for instance, in Great Britain, where the British parliament suggested in 2018 to classify social media platforms neither as a platform nor as a publisher, but to formulate a new category for them (House of Commons, Digital, Culture, Media and Sport Committee, 2018). Companies in that new category should then be required to take responsibility for the content that users share on their sites. Furthermore, the European Commission (2020b) proposed a Digital Services Act in December 2020, which covers among other things to require platforms to be transparent about removing illegal content, to provide the source with a reason for the removal, and to create a way through which third parties can notify the platform of alleged illegal content. During the pandemic, governments also set guidelines on the censorship of posts and criminalizing the spread of false information on social media (Radu, 2020).

It is important to note that governmental control and control by other external actors are no panacea for regulating misinformation. First, it has been argued that past attempts of regulating social media platforms have not created substantial shifts, but have shown limited impact on increasing accountability and transparency (Margetts et al., 2021). Second, as the regulatory power shifts from platforms to external actors, it is unclear how these actors can be held accountable and how abuses power can be avoided (Chin et al., 2022). For instance, legal restrictions such as criminalizing disinformation could be used in the service of authoritarianism by limiting free speech (Dowdeswell & Goltz, 2020). Finally, social media platforms have created dependencies by providing critical infrastructure to reach citizens and audiences and gather their attention. Both legacy media and governments are therefore, to a certain extent, dependent on platforms (Helberger, 2020). Due to these dependencies, it is unclear if these actors will always arrive at conclusions that are in the best interest of users and citizens. It has therefore been argued that regulatory "solutions need to empower users—not organizations, companies, or states" (Dowdeswell & Goltz, 2020, p. 209).

In this study, we specifically focus on misinformation regulations in the form of two different regulatory policies: Cooperation with journalistic fact-checkers and increased governmental regulation. Fact-checking encompasses efforts to investigate the accuracy of claims in the public domain. Fact-checking services can be individuals and organizations within journalistic outlets or independent of those like CheckYourFact.com or Snopes.com (Brandtzaeg et al., 2018; Krause et al., 2020). We focus on fact-checking services that are located within journalistic outlets, i.e., on journalistic fact-checkers. Governmental regulation, in turn, addresses the call for tightening legal frameworks around the spread of (mis-)information on social media. We are specifically interested in these dimensions, since both reflect an increasing interference of traditional democratic institutions on social media as a new, less institutionalized informational space. Furthermore, as outlined above, these dimensions reflect common approaches and discourses to addressing misinformation on social media.

PERCEPTIONS OF THE ISSUE THE POLICY IS ABOUT: THE PROBLEM OF MISINFORMATION

Policies often restrict freedoms that people or organizations would usually have. Policies regarding misinformation intrude into everyone's free speech. It is, therefore, unlikely that people would blindly support regulation, without seeing a problem with the issue. In the case of misinformation, this means that if people see misinformation as a problem, they might support policies against it. Possible indicators of the problem of misinformation are exposure to misinformation and the societal harm of misinformation.

Effects of the perceived exposure to misinformation

Although institutions (World Health Organization, 2020) and journalists (Fisher, 2021) warned about the large-scale diffusion of misinformation on social media, empirical evidence so far challenges the notion that misinformation was omnipresent in individuals' information environments. Studies before the COVID-19 pandemic highlight that misinformation only constitutes a small share of individuals' overall information intake (Allen et al., 2020; Guess et al., 2019). However, for the formation of attitudes toward regulations, citizens' perceived exposure to misinformation might be more relevant than their actual exposure to it.

While perceived and actual exposure are related, the two concepts can also drift apart in certain situations. Individuals might falsely identify information as misinformation or vice versa, for instance, when it contradicts their partisan beliefs (Bagó et al., 2020; Calvillo et al., 2020), especially when they are angry (Weeks, 2015). In addition, actual misinformation might stay unnoticed, when individuals perceive it as trustworthy based on the source that shared it or the congruency with their ideology (Allcott & Gentzkow, 2017; Freiling et al., 2023). Only when individuals *perceive* the presence of misinformation, be it righteously or erroneously, they might feel that it negatively affects them in their information-seeking behaviors and therefore perceive misinformation as a problem that affects them personally. Since citizens report to come across false or misleading information mostly on social media (IPSOS, 2019), this perceived misinformation exposure might especially influence their attitudes toward misinformation regulation on these platforms. We therefore expect:

H1: *Perceived misinformation exposure positively influences support for misinformation regulation on social media over time.*

Effects of the perceived harm of misinformation

Going beyond their own encounters with misinformation, individuals might also base their attitudes toward misinformation regulations on the perceived societal harm of misinformation. Scholars and public debates highlight several ways in which misinformation might inflict harm onto society: First, misinformation might mislead citizens on issues of central political importance, which can have a notable impact on public opinion and therefore collective decision-making, including electoral outcomes (Hameleers, 2022; Nyhan, 2020). Second, even if misinformation cannot fully convince citizens, it might instill uncertainty around facts for which expert consensus exists and also weaken individuals' trust in authorities as information sources by presenting alternative narratives (Bennett & Livingston, 2018; Flore, 2020). Third, even if corrected, misinformation might take away media attention from other important topics and thus could affect which issues are discussed (Flynn et al., 2017; Guo & Vargo, 2020).

While citizens themselves often feel unaffected by misinformation, they are concerned that others are exposed to and influenced by inaccurate information (Wagner & Boczkowski, 2019). Almost two thirds (64%) of Americans voiced concerns that made-up news stories have caused “a great deal of confusion about the basic facts of current events” (Barthel et al., 2016, p. 3). Similarly, an IPSOS (2019) survey in 25 countries shows that the majority of citizens strongly or somewhat agree that false information negatively affects politics (83%) and political discussion (83%) in their respective countries. These concerns might now be fueled by intensive public discourses around the harmful impact of misinformation during the COVID-19 pandemic (Scheufele et al., 2021).

The influence of presumed influence model (Gunther & Storey, 2006) predicts that such perceptions of negative influences of mass media on others can have meaningful effects on public opinion. This presumed influence can affect individuals’ attitudes and behaviors toward regulations of media content (Chung & Moon, 2016). Evidence shows that the perception of presumed influence is especially relevant to explain individuals’ attitudes toward censorship of potentially harmful media content such as pornographic content (Tal-Or et al., 2010) or video games (Schmierbach et al., 2011).

There is also evidence for the influence of presumed influence being applicable to individuals’ support for misinformation regulation. When others are perceived as susceptible to the influence of made-up news stories, so-called “fake news,” support for governmental

regulation (Cheng & Chen, 2020) and sanctions (Baek et al., 2019) increases. Perceptions of the influence of fake news, or made-up news stories, on others even emerged as a stronger predictor for support of fake news regulation when tested against similar concepts such as third-party perceptions or the influence on oneself (Lee, 2021). Extending these findings from the concept of fake news that was narrowly defined in these studies as made-up news to a more encompassing notion of misinformation, we expect the following:

H2: *Perceived misinformation harm positively influences support for misinformation regulation on social media over time.*

Extending this, especially when the perceived misinformation harm is low, perceived misinformation exposure might not lead to an increase in policy support. There are at least two reasons for that. First, besides potentially harmful disinformation campaigns, misinformation also encompasses claims that might be perceived as harmless. Intervening on harmless claims might end up changing some attributes of the respective claim, like its algorithmic traction or elite salience, making them potentially more harmful (Krause et al., 2022). As these different forms of claims feed into citizens' overall misinformation perceptions, the mere presence of misinformation might not always cause support for misinformation regulation. When individuals' overall perception of misinformation is that misinformation is harmful for society, it can be assumed that this would make them more supportive of regulating misinformation they see in their own information environment.

Second, research on the influence of presumed influence has shown that when media messages are perceived as affecting oneself and others jointly, this perception of a common issue additionally boosts support for regulations of harmful media messages (Baek et al., 2019; Neuwirth & Frederick, 2002). In that case, "the potential negative effect of the media becomes 'our' problem" (Baek et al., 2019, p. 436) that concerns everyone. Subsequently, when individuals simultaneously perceive that misinformation compromises their own information environment and see it as harmful for society at large, this might increase policy support for misinformation regulation. We, therefore, assume:

H3: *The positive effect of misinformation harm on support for misinformation regulation on social media over time is stronger for those who have higher levels of perceived misinformation exposure.*

THE ROLE OF TRUST IN THE REGULATION OF MISINFORMATION

Besides the perceived exposure to misinformation and its presumed effect on others, individuals might also reject policies that regulate the spread of misinformation based on their distrust toward actors and processes responsible for enacting such regulations. In the context of potential policies that we examine in this study—the state intervening and the requirement of social media platforms to work with journalistic fact-checkers—these actors are journalistic fact-checkers, or the media, more broadly, and the democratic system as a whole.

Media trust

Citizens' support of regulation requiring platforms to cooperate with journalistic fact-checkers likely roots in their predisposition toward legacy media actors, specifically their media trust.

Fact-checking, or tracking back the source of information and verifying claims, constitutes a core practice of journalism (Brandtzaeg et al., 2018). Furthermore, most fact-checkers would characterize themselves as journalists (Graves & Cherubini, 2016).

Journalistic fact-checkers have occupied an important position in the fight against misinformation in many countries (Graves & Cherubini, 2016). Some individuals, however, are skeptical toward fact-checking and challenge fact-checkers' authory in evaluating truth claims. This skepticism is mainly due to an overall distrust in fact-checkers' motives and objectivity, while some individuals also question fact-checkers' abilities (Brandtzaeg et al., 2018).

This rejection of fact-checking by some mirrors the decline in media trust among certain parts of the population. While media trust in Germany has remained relatively high and stable as compared to other countries (Newman et al., 2021), certain groups are marked by especially high levels of distrust in the general media landscape. In right-wing populist discourses in Europe, for example, "the media" are often portrayed as part of lying elites, which stand in opposition to "the people" as a source of truth (Hameleers, 2020). Similarly, in the United States, both conservatives and those low in media trust tend to associate mainstream media with the spread of misinformation by labeling it "fake news" to express their disagreement with the content and try to delegitimize the content (van der Linden et al., 2020).

Low levels of media trust might spill over to a rejection of misinformation regulation for at least two reasons: First, those with low media trust might turn to social media to fulfill their informational needs, as indicated by a negative relationship between media trust and social media use across several Western countries in survey data (Fletcher & Park, 2017; Kalogeropoulos et al., 2019) and focus group data (Andı, 2021). Thus, they might feel that regulations curtail their ability to freely and fully inform themselves through social media, which they chose to circumvent journalistic curation and selection in the first place.

Second, attitudes toward the media are likely to spill over to attitudes toward fact-checking, since fact-checking is seen as part of a larger media system and as a journalistic practice (Lyons et al., 2020). In countries with higher media trust and institutional trust overall, fact-checking receives more public support (Lyons et al., 2020). Similarly, more frequent users of mainstream media tend to be more aware and favorable toward fact-checking and also use fact-checking sites more often (Robertson et al., 2020). In summary, those with low levels of media trust are likely to oppose the regulation of misinformation on social media due to their low trust in journalistic practices overall and their reliance on non-journalistic streams of information on social media. We therefore expect:

H4: *Media trust positively influences support for misinformation regulation on social media over time.*

Trust in democracy

Trust in democracy "is the expectation that the democratic process will be fair and that democratic competition and decision-making will take place within the boundaries of agreed upon norms and principles" (Tsfati & Cohen, 2005, p. 32). One of these principles is the freedom of speech, which is, for instance, protected by Article 5(1) of Germany's constitution. In the context of regulating misinformation, individuals with high trust in democracy might therefore be less likely to support policies that regulate free speech.

In the context of decision-making and societal actions in democracies, it can be argued, however, that it is important that these decisions and actions are based on accurate information (Garrett et al., 2016; Tsfati & Cohen, 2005). Trust in democracy to lay the

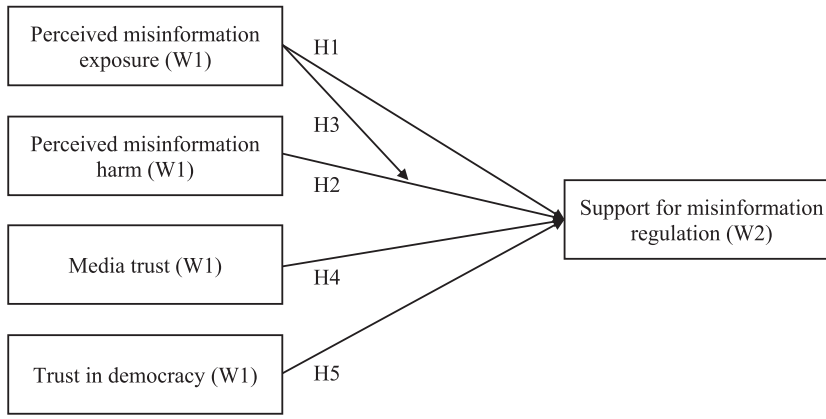

FIGURE 1 Hypothesized model predicting support for misinformation regulation on social media. For clarity reasons, control variables age, gender, education, social media use, ideology, conspiratorial thinking, and the autoregressive effect are not shown. W1 = wave 1, W2 = wave 2.

grounds for a life in line with democratic ideals in that country can, hence, also mean that individuals trust the democracy in their country to create a healthy information environment, for which regulations might be needed. Following this line of argument, individuals might further trust that the democracy in their country works so well that they can rely on regulations of misinformation not being too intrusive into their right to free speech.

Research on political trust more broadly and trust in democracy in particular indicates that individuals with higher trust are less opposed to policies. In the context of resisting policies, Müller (2013, p. 18) argues that "distrust in the principles of the political system might lead to protests to change these principles." In fact, individuals with higher trust in democracy are less likely to forcefully resist policies (Tsfati & Cohen, 2005). Furthermore, political trust positively influences support for government spending (Rudolph & Evans, 2005). Based on the evidence on trust in democracy and policy support, we assume:

H5: *Trust in democracy positively influences support for misinformation regulation on social media over time.*

For an overview of the hypothesized model, see Figure 1.

METHOD

Design

We conducted a two-wave panel survey ($N = 901$) with quotas for age, gender, and education in Germany. The survey was conducted in German with the panel provider Dynata in 2020. This study is part of a larger survey covering other social media-related issues. Due to the focus of the survey, only social media users between 18 and 65 years were targeted. Building on prior research, a time interval of about 6 months between both panel waves has been used (Gil de Zúñiga et al., 2014; Schumann et al., 2021). In light of the variables under investigation, a time period of several months was considered suitable. This decision was made due to the anticipated gradual and slow nature of changes in policy support. Moreover, this study intentionally selected a time frame that is not during an

ongoing election to obtain a more comprehensive understanding of the relationships under investigation. In wave 1 (February 20 to March 2), 2208 individuals completed our survey. We excluded speeders who finished the 25 min survey in less than 10 min, arriving at 1870 valid cases in wave 1.[1] In wave 2 (September 24 to October 10), 905 completed the survey. No further speeders were excluded. Four cases could not be matched, resulting in $N = 901$ cases for the analysis. Respondents were, on average, $M = 48.07$ years old (SD = 11.29), with 49.83% identifying as female. 15.32% have a low education, 68.81% have an intermediate one, and 15.87% of participants have a high education.[2]

Measures

Unless indicated differently, all items were measured on a 7-point scale from 1—strongly disagree to 7—strongly agree. All item wordings are presented in the Supporting Information (Table S1).

Before asking respondents questions related to misinformation, we defined misinformation to them, using a broad definition: "By misinformation we mean statements, reports, pictures, and videos that immediately or later turn out to be false. They can appear in different media, such as newspapers, on social media, or in messages from acquaintances."

Support for misinformation regulation on social media was measured by asking participants about their agreement with four statements on political measures to control misinformation on social media. Since the study investigates governmental and journalistic misinformation regulation, two items addressed governmental regulation (adapted from Baek et al., 2019), and two self-constructed items addressed journalistic regulation. We merged the items to an index (1–7, Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.93$; $\alpha_{W2} = 0.93$; $M_{W1} = 4.61$, $SD_{W1} = 1.71$; $M_{W2} = 4.62$, $SD_{W2} = 1.75$).[3]

Perceived misinformation harm was measured by asking respondents about their agreement with five items. One item was adapted from Barthel et al. (2016), and to capture additional facets of the societal harm of misinformation (see, e.g., Flynn et al., 2017), four self-formulated items were added to form an index (1–7, Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.95$, $M_{W1} = 5.09$, $SD_{W1} = 1.46$).

Perceived misinformation exposure was measured in line with our understanding of misinformation as an umbrella term for different types of false information, asking respondents on a 7-point scale (1—never, 7—very often) how often they saw five specific types of misinformation in the last 3 months. The items were adapted from Newman et al. (2018) and complemented with forms of content that draw false connections, are misleading, fabricated, manipulated, or appear in a false context (Wardle, 2019). We merged the five items to an index (1–7, Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.95$, $M_{W1} = 3.39$, $SD_{W1} = 1.62$).

Media trust was measured by asking respondents about their agreement with four statements about how traditional media cover political issues taken from Kohring and Matthes (2007). We merged the items to an index (1–7, Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.93$, $M_{W1} = 4.57$, $SD_{W1} = 1.41$).

Trust in democracy was measured by asking respondents about their agreement with two statements adapted from Wagner et al. (2018) (Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.92$, $M_{W1} = 3.84$, $SD_{W1} = 1.71$).

Controls. We control for social media use (time spent on the following platforms, with 1—no time at all, 7—a lot of time: Facebook: $M_{W1} = 3.44$, $SD_{W1} = 2.03$; YouTube: $M_{W1} = 3.62$, $SD_{W1} = 1.84$; Twitter: $M_{W1} = 1.78$, $SD_{W1} = 1.53$; Instagram: $M_{W1} = 2.24$, $SD_{W1} = 1.91$; Instant Messaging: $M_{W1} = 4.13$, $SD_{W1} = 1.95$), ideology (0—left to 10—right, $M_{W1} = 4.84$, $SD_{W1} = 1.86$), conspiratorial thinking (agreement to three statements, 1–7, Cronbach's $\alpha_{W1} = 0.78$,

$M_{W1} = 4.58$, $SD_{W1} = 1.36$) (Bruder et al., 2013), and demographics (see Supporting Information: Table S1 for more details on the measures).

RESULTS

The analyses were conducted in SPSS 26. To make sure that participants' support of misinformation did not change due to external events in the 6 months between our panel waves such as the information environment surrounding the pandemic being discussed widely as an infodemic (Simon & Camargo, 2021; World Health Organization, 2020) and social media companies taking measures to combat misinformation on their platform, like Facebook creating its oversight board (Medzini, 2022), we conducted a dependent *t* test that shows that there is no difference in support for misinformation regulation on social media between the waves, $t(900)$, $p = 0.88$ ($M_{W1} = 4.61$, $SD_{W1} = 1.71$; $M_{W2} = 4.62$, $SD_{W2} = 1.75$).

To test our hypotheses, we used a multiple linear regression controlling for an autoregressive effect (Table 1). We entered the variables stepwise into the regression model, which is portrayed in the different models in Table 1. Model 1 includes the dependent variable in wave 1 to control for the autoregressive effect as well as other controls, and explains about a quarter of the variance of support for misinformation regulation on social media in wave 2. Model 2 adds to that the independent variables. The independent variables additionally explained 3.5% of the variance, $\Delta R^2 = 0.04$, $\Delta F\ (4, 880) = 10.79$, $p < 0.001$. Model 3 includes on top of all those variables also the interaction. Including the interaction did not result in a change in the explained variance, $\Delta R^2 = 0.00$, $\Delta F\ (1, 879) = 0.615$, $p = 0.433$. The final model (Model 3) explains 28.2% of the variance.

Perceived misinformation exposure did not influence support for misinformation regulation on social media over time ($\beta = -0.05$, $p = 0.120$), not supporting H1. Perceived misinformation harm, however, positively influenced support for misinformation regulation on social media over time ($\beta = 0.07$, $p = 0.041$), supporting H2. There was no significant interaction of perceived misinformation harm and perceived misinformation exposure on support for misinformation regulation on social media over time ($\beta = 0.02$, $p = 0.433$), not supporting H3.

Media trust positively influenced support for misinformation regulation on social media over time ($\beta = 0.11$, $p = 0.002$), as did trust in democracy ($\beta = 0.11$, $p = 0.003$), supporting H4 and H5, respectively.

DISCUSSION

With the rise of the internet in general and social media in particular, there have been great hopes that free access to information by anyone and at any time would empower citizens and revolutionize modern democracy around the globe. However, with online misinformation being frequently discussed during the last decade, and especially during the COVID-19 pandemic, at least some of these hopes seem to have turned to disillusionment. Consequently, governments, news organizations, and social media platforms have been called to combat the uncontrolled spreading of misinformation, for instance, by monitoring, fact-checking, or ultimately deleting misinformation on social media and blocking its originators. However, misinformation regulations have to be carefully weighed against free speech, allowing the open expression of opinions in a real deliberative process, even if controversial.

Therefore, support for regulatory responses to misinformation is highly relevant. Against this background, using a two-wave panel study, the aim of this paper was to unravel the predictors that lead citizens to support stricter policies against misinformation.

TABLE 1 Multiple linear regression results controlling for the autoregressive effect explaining support for misinformation regulation on social media (W2).

	Model 1 B (SE)	Model 2 B (SE)	Model 3 B (SE)
(Intercept)	2.37 (0.41)***	1.28 (0.44)**	1.23 (0.45)**
Support for misinformation regulation (W1)	0.50 (0.03)***	0.42 (0.03)***	0.42 (0.03)***
Age	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)
Gender (female coded high)	0.15 (0.11)	0.17 (0.10)	0.17 (0.10)
Education: medium (ref.: low)	0.19 (0.14)	0.16 (0.14)	0.16 (0.14)
Education: high (ref.: low)	0.22 (0.19)	0.12 (0.18)	0.12 (0.18)
Social media use: Facebook	0.00 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)
Social media use: YouTube	−0.01 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)
Social media use: Twitter	0.07 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)
Social media use: Instagram	−0.02 (0.04)	−0.03 (0.04)	−0.03 (0.04)
Social media use: Instant messaging	0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)
Ideology (right coded high)	0.03 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)
Conspiratorial thinking	−0.05 (0.04)	−0.02 (0.04)	−0.02 (0.04)
Perceived misinformation exposure	–	−0.05 (0.04)	−0.06 (0.04)
Perceived misinformation harm	–	0.09 (0.04)*	0.09 (0.04)*
Media trust	–	0.14 (0.04)**	0.14 (0.04)**
Trust in democracy	–	0.11 (0.04)**	0.11 (0.04)**
Perceived misinformation exposure * Perceived misinformation harm	–	–	0.04 (0.05)
R^2	0.26	0.30	0.30
Adjusted R^2	0.25	0.28	0.28
ΔR^2		0.04	0.00
ΔF		10.78***	0.62

Note: W1 = wave 1, W2 = wave 2.
*$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$; ***$p < 0.001$.

Before discussing our results, the following limitations need to be considered. Our perceptual survey measures might have introduced some bias. We measured exposure to misinformation as a perception, and perceptions may not correspond to the real amount of misinformation individuals are exposed to. However, it can be argued that perceptions are even more important for policy attitudes than the actual amount of misinformation. That is, if people are exposed to misinformation but do not realize it, they may see no need for policy intervention. Still, future studies could get more insights into how actual exposure to misinformation influences support of misinformation regulation by using an experimental design or a design that combines survey data with actual exposure data via data donations of participants' social media use.

Future research is also needed to better explain what individuals understand as "harm" of misinformation. We offered the notion of the influence of presumed influence as an explanation. Clearly, this mechanism needs to be empirically examined, ideally in experimental settings. Related to that, some harms like an influence on election results or vaccination hesitancy may be perceived as more consequential and important than others. There are also attributes of information that influence the information's actual harm. Krause et al. (2022) outline how those attributes can also interact, which might influence a claim's actual harm as well. Of course, the actual harm of a claim may also influence individuals' perceptions of the harm. Consequently, future research should separate several dimensions of harm and examine how they influence the perceived harm of the claim as well as the perceived support for regulating those claims. The same argument applies to several types of misinformation.

In our measures, we used the term misinformation in very general terms, also including purposefully misleading disinformation (Krause et al., 2020; Scheufele & Krause, 2019). It could be that the difference between misinformation, which some define as false without intent to mislead, and disinformation, which some define as intentionally false (Westlund & Hermida, 2021), matters when explaining policy attitudes. Perhaps regulations fighting disinformation find more public approval as compared to regulations against the spread of mistakes that were not intended. More research is clearly needed to shed light on this. However, since it is impossible to read the minds of sources of mis- and disinformation, and it is therefore often impossible to know whether they shared the false information intentionally or not, we used misinformation as an umbrella term in this study.

The use of two-wave panel data does not allow us to make any assumptions about reinforcing processes and intraindividual change. While panel data models the correct temporal order of effects, the influence of third variables that were not accounted for in our models cannot be fully ruled out. Thus, causality cannot be fully established with this type of data. Furthermore, there is currently no theoretical framework that can guide the decision about an optimal time lag for the effects under study. The temporal effects of, for instance, perceived misinformation exposure might be more short-lived and therefore not detectable using our study design. Therefore, future research could also use shorter time lags and multiple waves of data collection to gain a fuller picture of potential effects.

The context of our study might have influenced our findings as we conducted it during the rise of the COVID-19 pandemic. Additionally, this study was conducted in Germany, where the Network Enforcement Law was already in place for more than 2 years at the time of the study and where people are generally ascribing more responsibility for content moderation to the state and to social media platforms than, for instance, in the United States (Riedl, Naab, et al., 2021). Future research could test if the results replicate in other temporal and regulatory contexts.

Finally, a current problem of policies against misinformation is, of course, that they are only binding on a national level. However, even regulations at a European Union level cannot regulate platforms completely, since platforms operate globally, and misinformation travels across these borders. For explaining attitudes toward regulation, there is therefore an urgent need for cross-country research, ideally modeling the influence of macro-factors (e.g., the state of democracy, policy polarization, or the political and media systems) as well as the interaction of micro- and macro-factors in multilevel models.

With those considerations in mind, we find that the amount of perceived misinformation did not predict policy attitudes over time. In other words, the perception of being exposed to false stories, manipulated images and videos, or twisted facts alone is not sufficient for citizens to support stricter regulation. What matters, however, is the perceived harm of such misinformation. In line with the argument by Krause et al. (2022) and the influence of presumed influence model (Gunther & Storey, 2006), these results may indicate that people

distinguish in their overall misinformation perceptions between misinformation that is harmful and therefore more in need of interventions and misinformation that is harmless and should better not be regulated. This is a positive finding for democracy, given that people seem to not want to restrict freedom of speech if not absolutely necessary, in other words, just because they saw nonharmful misinformation. This suggests that it may be helpful for practitioners to evaluate the harm of specific misinformation instead of trying to intervene against any potential misinformation they spot. For a framework that could be used for this, see Krause et al. (2022). A similar distinction between harmful and not harmful types of misinformation could also guide future policymaking. To further corroborate this interpretation, future studies investigating the perceived harmfulness of specific claims and the influence of that on support for misinformation regulation are needed.

The perceived amount of misinformation also did not interact with the perceived harm for explaining regulation attitudes, but the perceived harm of misinformation positively influenced support for regulating misinformation. This means that the harm of misinformation, even when citizens have the impression of not being personally exposed to it, drives attitudes. This result suggests that societal debates about misinformation in general and media coverage in particular may be very important. That is, some individuals may learn about the spreading of misinformation in mass media, without having the impression of being exposed to it in their own networks. An example is the debate about misinformation on COVID-19: If people hear a lot about how harmful misinformation can be, this might influence their perceptions of the influence of misinformation. For media practitioners, this means that public debates around the harm of misinformation should be evidence-based and avoid an alarmist tone when not warranted, since the public might otherwise call for increased regulation even when the scope of the issue might not justify such measures.

At the same time, the nonsignificant interaction also implies that the perceived exposure to misinformation has no consequences, even when people believe this information will do great harm. This may be explained by people having the impression that they can effectively deal with the misinformation themselves once they see it. What matters, however, is the impression that misinformation has the potential to do harm to *others*, as for instance, by influencing public opinion, shaping the public discussion about topics, creating confusion among other citizens, or influencing elections. Taking these findings together, there might be a third-person effect (Davison, 1983) if people believe exposure to misinformation is not harmful to them, but is harmful to others. Of course, more data, particularly about the underlying mechanisms, are needed to corroborate these claims.

Furthermore, our results show that trust in news media positively predicted support for misinformation regulation. An explanation for this is that in line with previous data showing a negative relationship between media trust and social media use (Andı, 2021; Fletcher & Park, 2017; Kalogeropoulos et al., 2019), it seems that those who are distrustful of the media may have to rely on the information provided via their social networks and that regulation of social media may therefore be disadvantageous for their information needs. Also, previous research showed that fact-checking is seen as part of a larger media system and as a journalistic practice (Lyons et al., 2020), so citizens' attitudes toward the media, may spill over to attitudes toward fact-checking, since fact-checking is often done by journalists. In line with literature on trust in democracy leading to less resistance against policies (Müller, 2013; Tsfati & Cohen, 2005), our data also showed a positive over-time relationship between trust in democracy and policy support for misinformation regulation. This can be explained similarly to media trust: Those who trust democracy in general may also be more willing to accept policies that defend democracy. Additionally, those with higher trust in democracy may also put more trust in a society's capacity to separate true from false information. As an alternative interpretation, one could also speculate that policy support for misinformation regulation may be a matter of trust. That is, trust in media as well as trust in democracy and

support for regulations may have a common core or underlying variance, and that is why they are related. For this, it is important to note that our models controlled for the prior state of policy attitudes in an autoregressive model minimizing issues of spuriousness and unclear causal order. However, more evidence and more research are needed to fully explain these relationships.

CONCLUSION

The last decade, and particularly the COVID-19 crisis, has shown that for a healthy democracy, there is an increasing need to regulate social media also externally instead of only relying on the platforms to self-regulate. As necessary as misinformation regulations may be perceived, as important it is to carefully weigh them against the virtue of free speech in society. In this complex debate, public approval of misinformation regulations becomes a very important factor. Our study shows that the perceived harm of misinformation and not the perceived amount of exposure matters for regulation attitudes. This finding highlights how important it is to understand the actual and perceived harms of misinformation. Scholars, fact-checkers, journalists, and policymakers need to engage in an informed debate about which harms are likely to occur, how they are perceived by society, and how they can be prevented. To determine some parts of the potential harm, scholars will need more comprehensive access to social media data, including underlying algorithms, than they currently have (Freiling et al., 2021; Scheufele, 2022). Not knowing, for example, how exactly algorithms prioritize content means not being to determine a crucial attribute of a claim's harm: how much algorithmic traction it will get (Krause et al., 2022). To be able to engage in an informed debate about harms of misinformation, the cooperation of platforms or regulations addressing access to data for scholars will be needed as well.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data underlying this article will be shared on reasonable request to the corresponding author.

ORCID

Isabelle Freiling http://orcid.org/0000-0002-6046-4005
Marlis Stubenvoll http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1870-0403
Jörg Matthes http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9408-955X

ENDNOTES

[1] Response times can be a meaningful indicator for careless responses (Leiner, 2019). Being conservative in our exclusion criteria, we only excluded participants who took less than 10 min for a survey of 25 min, as this short response time indicates that participants did not read items and instructions for a majority of questions.

[2] Low education: No school degree, elementary school, or secondary school degree; medium education: vocational school or high school degree; high education: technical school, technical college, or college degree.

[3] For every index that consists of more than two variables, we conducted a principal component analysis using oblimin rotation of the single variables to ensure that all items load on one factor, which they did.

REFERENCES

Allcott, H., & Gentzkow, M. (2017). Social media and fake news in the 2016 election. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, *31*(2), 211–236. https://doi.org/10.1257/jep.31.2.211

Allen, J., Howland, B., Mobius, M., Rothschild, D., & Watts, D. J. (2020). Evaluating the fake news problem at the scale of the information ecosystem. *Science Advances*, *6*(14), eaay3539. https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.aay3539

Andersson Schwarz, J. (2017). Platform logic: An interdisciplinary approach to the platform-based economy. *Policy & Internet*, *9*(4), 374–394. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.159

Andı, S. (2021). *How and why do consumers access news on social media*? https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2021/how-and-why-do-consumers-access-news-social-media

Baek, Y. M., Kang, H., & Kim, S. (2019). Fake news should be regulated because it influences both "others" and "me": How and why the influence of presumed influence model should be extended. *Mass Communication and Society*, *22*(3), 301–323. https://doi.org/10.1080/15205436.2018.1562076

Bago, B., Rand, D. G., & Pennycook, G. (2020). Fake news, fast and slow: Deliberation reduces belief in false (but not true) news headlines. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, *149*(8), 1608–1613. https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0000729

Baker, S. A., Wade, M., & Walsh, M. J. (2020). The challenges of responding to misinformation during a pandemic: Content moderation and the limitations of the concept of harm. *Media International Australia*, *177*(1), 103–107. https://doi.org/10.1177/1329878x20951301

Banko, M., MacKeen, B., & Ray, L. (2020). A unified taxonomy of harmful content. *Proceedings of the Fourth Workshop on Online Abuse and Harms*, 125–137. https://doi.org/10.18653/v1/2020.alw-1.16

Barthel, M., Mitchell, A., & Holcomb, J. (2016). *Many Americans believe fake news is sowing confusion*. https://assets.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/13/2016/12/14154753/PJ_2016.12.15_fake-news_FINAL.pdf

Bennett, W. L., & Livingston, S. (2018). The disinformation order: Disruptive communication and the decline of democratic institutions. *European Journal of Communication*, *33*(2), 122–139. https://doi.org/10.1177/0267323118760317

Brandtzaeg, P. B., Følstad, A., & Chaparro Domínguez, M. Á. (2018). How journalists and social media users perceive online fact-checking and verification services. *Journalism Practice*, *12*(9), 1109–1129. https://doi.org/10.1080/17512786.2017.1363657

Bruder, M., Haffke, P., Neave, N., Nouripanah, N., & Imhoff, R. (2013). Measuring individual differences in generic beliefs in conspiracy theories across cultures: Conspiracy mentality questionnaire. *Frontiers in Psychology*, *4*, 225. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00225

Calvillo, D. P., Ross, B. J., Garcia, R. J. B., Smelter, T. J., & Rutchick, A. M. (2020). Political ideology predicts perceptions of the threat of COVID-19 (and susceptibility to fake news about it). *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, *11*(8), 1119–1128. https://doi.org/10.1177/1948550620940539

Cheng, Y., & Chen, Z. F. (2020). The influence of presumed fake news influence: Examining public support for corporate corrective response, media literacy interventions, and governmental regulation. *Mass Communication and Society*, *23*(5), 705–729. https://doi.org/10.1080/15205436.2020.1750656

Chin, Y. C., Park, A., & Li, K. (2022). A comparative study on false information governance in Chinese and American social media platforms. *Policy & Internet*, *14*(2), 263–283. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.301

Chung, S., & Moon, S.-I. (2016). Is the third-person effect real? A critical examination of rationales, testing methods, and previous findings of the third-person effect on censorship attitudes: Third-person effect. *Human Communication Research*, *42*(2), 312–337. https://doi.org/10.1111/hcre.12078

Culliford, E. (2020, April 28). YouTube expands fact-check feature to U.S. video searches during COVID-19 pandemic. *Reuters*. https://www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-alphabet-youtube-factchecking-idUSKCN22A2Y1

Davison, W. P. (1983). The third-person effect in communication. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, *47*, 1–15.

DeCook, J. R., Cotter, K., Kanthawala, S., & Foyle, K. (2022). Safe from "harm": The governance of violence by platforms. *Policy & Internet*, *14*(1), 63–78. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.290

Dowdeswell, T. L., & Goltz, N. (2020). The clash of empires: Regulating technological threats to civil society. *Information & Communications Technology Law*, *29*(2), 194–217. https://doi.org/10.1080/13600834.2020.1735060

Duffy, C. (2021, September 1). For misinformation peddlers on social media, it's three strikes and you're out. Or five. Maybe more. *CNN*. https://edition.cnn.com/2021/09/01/tech/social-media-misinformation-strike-policies/index.html

Egelhofer, J. L., & Lecheler, S. (2019). Fake news as a two-dimensional phenomenon: A framework and research agenda. *Annals of the International Communication Association*, *43*(2), 97–116. https://doi.org/10.1080/23808985.2019.1602782

Einwiller, S. A., & Kim, S. (2020). How online content providers moderate user-generated content to prevent harmful online communication: An analysis of policies and their implementation. *Policy & Internet*, *12*(2), 184–206. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.239

European Commission. (2020a). *Coronavirus: EU strengthens action to tackle disinformation*. https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_20_1006

European Commission. (2020b). *Proposal for a regulation of the European Parliament and of the Council on a Single Market For Digital Services (Digital Services Act) and amending Directive*. https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/en/TXT/?qid=1608117147218&uri=COM%3A2020%3A825%3AFIN

Fisher, M. (2021, May 7). 'Belonging is stronger than facts': The age of misinformation. *The New York Times*. https://www.nytimes.com/2021/05/07/world/asia/misinformation-disinformation-fake-news.html

Fletcher, R., & Park, S. (2017). The impact of trust in the news media on online news consumption and participation. *Digital Journalism*, *5*(10), 1281–1299. https://doi.org/10.1080/21670811.2017.1279979

Flew, T. (2021). The global trust deficit disorder: A communications perspective on trust in the time of global pandemics. *Journal of Communication*, *71*(2), 163–186. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqab006

Flore, M. (2020). *Understanding ctizens' vulnerabilities (II): From disinformation to hostile narratives*. Publications Office of the European Union. https://doi.org/10.2760/271224

Flynn, D. J., Nyhan, B., & Reifler, J. (2017). The nature and origins of misperceptions: Understanding false and unsupported beliefs about politics. *Political Psychology*, *38*(S1), 127–150. https://doi.org/10.1111/pops.12394

Freiling, I., Krause, N. M., Scheufele, D. A., & Chen, K. (2021). The science of open (communication) science: Toward an evidence-driven understanding of quality criteria in communication research. *Journal of Communication*, *71*(5), 686–714. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqab032

Freiling, I., Krause, N. M., Scheufele, D. A., & Brossard, D. (2023). Believing and sharing misinformation, fact-checks, and accurate information on social media: The role of anxiety during COVID-19. *New Media & Society*, *25*(1), 141–162. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448211011451

Gani, A. (2021, December 26). Regulate, break up, open up: How to fix Facebook in 2022. *The Guardian*. https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2021/dec/25/facebook-how-to-fix-break-up-regulation

Garrett, R. K., Weeks, B. E., & Neo, R. L. (2016). Driving a wedge between evidence and beliefs: How online ideological news exposure promotes political misperceptions. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, *21*(5), 331–348. https://doi.org/10.1111/jcc4.12164

Gil de Zúñiga, H., Molyneux, L., & Zheng, P. (2014). Social media, political expression, and political participation: Panel analysis of lagged and concurrent relationships. *Journal of Communication*, *64*(4), 612–634. https://doi.org/10.1111/jcom.12103

Gorwa, R. (2019). What is platform governance? *Information, Communication & Society*, *22*(6), 854–871. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2019.1573914.

Graves, L., & Cherubini, F. (2016). *The rise of fact-checking sites in Europe*. Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism. https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/sites/default/files/research/files/The%2520Rise%2520of%2520Fact-Checking%2520Sites%2520in%2520Europe.pdf

Groß, S. (2021, March 1). Steinmeier fordert, soziale Medien stärker zu regulieren [Steinmeier calls for stronger regulation of social media]. *Sueddeutsche Zeitung*. https://www.sueddeutsche.de/politik/soziale-medien-bundespraesident-regulation-facebook-twitter-google-1.5221609

Guess, A., Nagler, J., & Tucker, J. (2019). Less than you think: Prevalence and predictors of fake news dissemination on Facebook. *Science Advances*, *5*(1), eaau4586. https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.aau4586

Gunther, A. C., & Storey, J. D. (2006). The influence of presumed influence. *Journal of Communication*, *53*(2), 199–215. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.2003.tb02586.x

Guo, L., & Vargo, C. (2020). "Fake news" and emerging online media ecosystem: An integrated intermedia agenda-setting analysis of the 2016 U.S. Presidential election. *Communication Research*, *47*(2), 178–200. https://doi.org/10.1177/0093650218777177

Hameleers, M. (2020). My reality is more truthful than yours: Radical right-wing politicians' and citizens' construction of "fake" and "truthfulness" on social media—Evidence from the United States and The Netherlands. *International Journal of Communication*, *14*, 1135–1152. https://ijoc.org/index.php/ijoc/article/view/12463

Hameleers, M. (2022). Disinformation as a context-bound phenomenon: toward a conceptual clarification integrating actors, intentions and techniques of creation and dissemination. *Communication Theory*, *33*, 1–10. https://doi.org/10.1093/ct/qtac021

Helberger, N. (2020). The political power of platforms: How current attempts to regulate misinformation amplify opinion power. *Digital Journalism*, *8*(6), 842–854. https://doi.org/10.1080/21670811.2020.1773888

House of Commons, Digital, Culture, Media and Sport Committee. (2018). *Disinformation and "Fake News": Final Report*. House of Commons.

IPSOS. (2019). *CIGI-IPSOS global survey. Internet security & trust 2019 part 3: Social media, fake news & algorithms*. https://www.cigionline.org/cigi-ipsos-global-survey-internet-security-and-trust/

Kalogeropoulos, A., Suiter, J., Udris, L., & Eisenegger, M. (2019). News media trust and news consumption: Factors related to trust in news in 35 countries [trust in news, social media, digital news consumption, Public Service Broadcaster, press freedom]. *International Journal of Communication*, *13*, 3672–3693. https://ijoc.org/index.php/ijoc/article/view/10141

Kohring, M., & Matthes, J. (2007). Trust in news media: Development and validation of a multidimensional scale. *Communication Research*, *34*(2), 231–252. https://doi.org/10.1177/0093650206298071

Krause, N. M., Freiling, I., & Scheufele, D. A. (2022). The infodemic 'infodemic:' Toward a more nuanced understanding of truth-claims and the need for (not) combatting misinformation. *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, *700*(1), 112–123. https://doi.org/10.1177/00027162221086263

Krause, N. M., Freiling, I., Beets, B., & Brossard, D. (2020). Fact-checking as risk communication: The multi-layered risk of misinformation in times of COVID-19. *Journal of Risk Research*, *23*(7–8), 1052–1059. https://doi.org/10.1080/13669877.2020.1756385

Lee, T. (2021). How people perceive influence of fake news and why it matters. *Communication Quarterly*, *69*(4), 431–453. https://doi.org/10.1080/01463373.2021.1954677

Leiner, D. J. (2019). Too fast, too straight, too weird: Non-reactive indicators for meaningless data in internet surveys. *Survey Research Methods*, *13*(3), 229–248. https://doi.org/10.18148/srm/2019.v13i3.7403

Lyons, B., Mérola, V., Reifler, J., & Stoeckel, F. (2020). How politics shape views toward fact-checking: Evidence from six European countries. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, *25*(3), 469–492. https://doi.org/10.1177/1940161220921732

Margetts, H., Lehdonvirta, V., González-Bailón, S., Hutchinson, J., Bright, J., Nash, V., & Sutcliffe, D. (2021). The Internet and public policy: Future directions. *Policy & Internet*, *13*(2), 162–184. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.263

Medzini, R. (2022). Enhanced self-regulation: The case of Facebook's content governance. *New Media & Society*, *24*(10), 2227–2251. https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444821989352

Morris, C. (2021). How misinformation primed Trump's supporters for Capitol riot. *IPSOS*. https://www.ipsos.com/en-us/how-misinformation-primed-trumps-supporters-capitol-riot

Mosseri, A. (2017). *Working to stop misinformation and false news*. https://about.fb.com/news/2017/04/working-to-stop-misinformation-and-false-news/

Müller, J. (2013). *Mechanisms of trust. News media in democratic and authoritarian regimes*. Campus.

Neuwirth, K., & Frederick, E. (2002). Extending the framework of third-, first-, and second-person effects. *Mass Communication and Society*, *5*(2), 113–140. https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327825MCS0502_2

Newman, N., Fletcher, R., Kalogeropoulos, A., Levy, D. A. L., & Nielsen, R. K. (2018). *Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2018*. https://s3-eu-west-1.amazonaws.com/media.digitalnewsreport.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/06/digital-news-report-2018.pdf

Newman, N., Fletcher, R., Schulz, A., Andı, S., Robertson, C. T., & Nielsen, R. K. (2021). *Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2021*. https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2021

Nooren, P., van Gorp, N., van Eijk, N., & Fathaigh, R. Ó. (2018). Should we regulate digital platforms? A new framework for evaluating policy options. *Policy & Internet*, *10*(3), 264–301. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.177

Nyhan, B. (2020). Facts and myths about misperceptions. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, *34*(3), 220–236. https://doi.org/10.1257/jep.34.3.220

Pohle, J., & Voelsen, D. (2022). Centrality and power. The struggle over the techno-political configuration of the Internet and the global digital order. *Policy & Internet*, *14*(1), 13–27. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.296

Posner, R. A. (1974). Theories of economic regulation. *The Bell Journal of Economics and Management Science*, *5*(2), 335–358.

Radu, R. (2020). Fighting the 'infodemic': Legal responses to COVID-19 disinformation. *Social Media + Society*, *6*(3), 2056305120948190. https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305120948190

Riedl, M. J., Whipple, K. N., & Wallace, R. (2021). Antecedents of support for social media content moderation and platform regulation: The role of presumed effects on self and others. *Information, Communication & Society*, *25*, 1–18. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2021.1874040

Riedl, M. J., Naab, T. K., Masullo, G. M., Jost, P., & Ziegele, M. (2021). Who is responsible for interventions against problematic comments? Comparing user attitudes in Germany and the United States. *Policy & Internet*, *13*(3), 433–451. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.257

Robertson, C. T., Mourão, R. R., & Thorson, E. (2020). Who uses fact-checking sites? The impact of demographics, political antecedents, and media use on fact-checking site awareness, attitudes, and behavior. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, *25*(2), 217–237. https://doi.org/10.1177/1940161219898055

Rudolph, T. J., & Evans, J. (2005). Political trust, ideology, and public support for government spending. *American Journal of Political Science*, *49*(3), 660–671. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5907.2005.00148.x

Scheufele, D. A. (2022). Understanding (perceptions of) emerging information ecologies. *Journalism & Communication Monographs*, *24*(2), 141–145. https://doi.org/10.1177/15226379221092022

Scheufele, D. A., & Krause, N. M. (2019). Science audiences, misinformation, and fake news. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America*, *116*(16), 7662–7669. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1805871115

Scheufele, D. A., Krause, N. M., & Freiling, I. (2021). Misinformed about the "infodemic?" Science's ongoing struggle with misinformation. *Journal of Applied Research in Memory and Cognition*, *10*(4), 522–526. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jarmac.2021.10.009

Schmierbach, M., Boyle, M. P., Xu, Q., & McLeod, D. M. (2011). Exploring Third-Person differences between gamers and nongamers. *Journal of Communication*, *61*(2), 307–327. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.2011.01541.x

Schoenebeck, S., & Blackwell, L. (2021). Reimagining social media governance: Harm, accountability, and repair. *Yale Journal of Law and Technology*, *23*(1), 113–152.

Schumann, S., Boer, D., Hanke, K., & Liu, J. (2021). Social media use and support for populist radical right parties: Assessing exposure and selection effects in a two-wave panel study. *Information, Communication & Society*, *24*(7), 921–940. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2019.1668455

Simon, F. M., & Camargo, C. Q. (2021). Autopsy of a metaphor: The origins, use and blind spots of the 'infodemic'. *New Media & Society*, *25*, 2219–2240. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448211031908

Tal-Or, N., Cohen, J., Tsfati, Y., & Gunther, A. C. (2010). Testing causal direction in the influence of presumed media influence. *Communication Research*, *37*(6), 801–824. https://doi.org/10.1177/0093650210362684

Tsfati, Y., & Cohen, J. (2005). Democratic consequences of hostile media perceptions: The case of Gaza settlers. *Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics*, *10*(4), 28–51. https://doi.org/10.1177/1081180x05280776

van der Linden, S., Panagopoulos, C., & Roozenbeek, J. (2020). You are fake news: Political bias in perceptions of fake news. *Media, Culture & Society*, *42*(3), 460–470. https://doi.org/10.1177/0163443720906992

Vraga, E. K., & Bode, L. (2020). Defining misinformation and understanding its bounded nature: Using expertise and evidence for describing misinformation. *Political Communication*, *37*(1), 136–144. https://doi.org/10.1080/10584609.2020.1716500

Wagner, M., Aichholzer, J., Eberl, J.-M., Meyer, T. M., Berk, N., Büttner, N., Boomgaarden, H., Kritzinger, S., & Müller, W. C. (2018). *AUTNES Online Panel Study 2017 (SUF edition)*, Version V4 [Numeric]. AUSSDA. https://doi.org/10.11587/I7QIYJ

Wagner, M. C., & Boczkowski, P. J. (2019). The reception of fake news: The interpretations and practices that shape the consumption of perceived misinformation. *Digital Journalism*, *7*(7), 870–885. https://doi.org/10.1080/21670811.2019.1653208

Wardle, C. (2019). First Draft's essential guide to understanding information disorder. First Draft. https://firstdraftnews.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/10/Information_Disorder_Digital_AW.pdf?x76701

Weeks, B. E. (2015). Emotions, partisanship, and misperceptions: How anger and anxiety moderate the effect of partisan bias on susceptibility to political misinformation. *Journal of Communication*, *65*(4), 699–719. https://doi.org/10.1111/jcom.12164

Westlund, O., & Hermida, A. (2021). Data journalism and misinformation. In H. Tumber, & S. Waisbord (Eds.), *The Routledge companion to media disinformation and populism* (pp. 142–150). Routledge.

World Health Organization. (2020). *Novel coronavirus (2019-nCoV). Situation Report – 13*. https://www.who.int/docs/default-source/coronaviruse/situation-reports/20200202-sitrep-13-ncov-v3.pdf

SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

How to cite this article: Freiling, I., Stubenvoll, M., & Matthes, J. (2023). Support for misinformation regulation on social media: It is the perceived harm of misinformation that matters, not the perceived amount. *Policy & Internet*, *15*, 731–749. https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.360